Twelve ways to decide

Choose the way before the discussion starts. Ask what this decision needs most: narrowing many options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say. Then pick one way from that group and write it on the canvas.

Narrow down options

Dot voting

How it works: Everyone places a few dots in one round. Then talk about the options at the top.

Use it when: A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.

Watch out: Popular isn't always right. Discuss the top options before you decide.

Multi-voting

How it works: Vote in rounds and drop the weakest option each time, until a shortlist remains.

Use it when: One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.

Watch out: It takes longer. Agree the number of rounds up front.

Scoring matrix

How it works: Rate each option against three to five agreed criteria, then compare totals and trade-offs.

Use it when: Every option has its own trade-offs.

Watch out: Agree the criteria before scoring, or people choose criteria that fit their favourite.

Decide quickly

Majority vote

How it works: One vote each. The option with more than half of the votes wins.

Use it when: There are two options and either would work.

Watch out: The losing side may not commit. Only use it when both options are acceptable.

Plurality

How it works: One vote each. The option with the most votes wins, even below half.

Use it when: There are several options and no time for more rounds.

Watch out: The winner may have less than half the room behind it.

Authority

How it works: One person hears from the people affected, then decides and explains why.

Use it when: One person is accountable for the outcome.

Watch out: Say up front that one person decides, and explain the decision afterwards.

Bring everyone along

Fist to five

How it works: Everyone shows zero to five fingers at the same time. Ask the lowest: what would raise your score by one?

Use it when: People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.

Watch out: Low scores need a conversation, not a new vote.

Consensus

How it works: Share a proposal, listen to concerns, adapt it, and check that everyone can back it.

Use it when: Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.

Watch out: Slow, and the most cautious person can block. Save it for decisions everyone must carry.

Consent

How it works: Ask for serious reasons not to try it. Resolve the valid objections, then go ahead.

Use it when: You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

Watch out: An objection needs a reason, a risk or harm, not just a preference.

Settle who has the final say

Supermajority

How it works: Agree a threshold, such as 75%, before voting. Go ahead only if you reach it.

Use it when: A big decision needs more than a narrow win.

Watch out: Set the threshold before the vote, never after.

Unanimity

How it works: Each person gives a clear yes or no. A single no sends the proposal back.

Use it when: Every person must actively agree before you move.

Watch out: One person can stop everything. Use it rarely.

Delegation

How it works: Choose who decides, and agree their mandate, limits and deadline.

Use it when: The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

Watch out: Write the mandate down, and don't overrule the person afterwards.

Combine them: narrow down with dot voting, then decide by consent. Whatever you choose, agree who decides, who is asked first, and who is told afterwards.

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